At lunchtime on 26 October 1962 John Scali ate a baloney sandwich at his desk. Scali was ABC News' State Department correspondent, who also presented a weekly TV current affairs programme, *Issues and Answers.* During the Nixon administration, he was to become US ambassador to the UN. After consuming his sandwich, Scali received a phone call from someone he knew as Aleksandr Fomin, a counsellor at the Soviet embassy. Historians now know him as Aleksandr Feklisov, the KGB *Rezident* in Washington. Scali knew Feklisov was an intelligence officer, having been told so by the FBI (who encouraged him to maintain contact). Feklisov was highly experienced (on his previous posting to the US, he was the case officer of Julius Rosenberg and Klaus Fuchs). In *Thirteen Days*, Feklisov is depicted as charmless and devious (in contrast to other Hollywood portrayals of KGB officers of the time, such as Mark Rylance's portrayal of the KGB's Rudolf Abel in Steven Spielberg's *Bridge of Spies*). The GRU's Georgi Bolshakov, it might be noted, was evidently a person of great wit and charm, as effective intelligence officers are apt to be.

Feklisov invited Scali for lunch at the Occidental Restaurant on Pennsylvania Avenue, down the road from the White House, where they met at 1.30pm. This, and their subsequent meetings, entered the folklore of the missile crisis. For many years, it was believed that a backchannel was established, connecting the Kremlin with the White House, which played a valuable (or at least helpful) part in the resolution of the crisis. In later years, a plaque appeared in the Occidental Restaurant where they sat: 'At this table during the tense moments of the Cuban missile crisis, a Russian offer to withdraw missiles from Cuba was passed by the mysterious "Mr X" to ABC-TV correspondent John Scali. On the basis of this meeting the threat of a possible nuclear war was avoided.'[26] The scene featured in the film *Thirteen Days.*

There are, however, very different interpretations of what happened (which illuminate some of the challenges facing Cold War historians). What is not in question is what Scali did after lunch. He went to the State Department and saw the Director of Intelligence and Research, Roger Hilsman. Scali's notes were typed, handed to Dean Rusk, and circulated to other key members of ExComm.[27] They contained the following outline for